Q+A

AIMING HIGH

For **Neeraj Chopra**, it's all about training consistency and keeping the sporting spirit alive



Q. At 25, you have reached the pinnacle of your sport, from winning an Olympic gold to being a World Champion. What motivates you the most?

For me, the most enjoyable part of my life as an athlete is the daily training. I like the routine of it. I focus on it and try to improve my lifts and jumps and eat healthier. As you train, you understand your body better. Even if you feel like having a cheat day, you think of all the work that's gone into attaining your level of fitness. And I haven't had one in a while now.

Q. There were three Indians in the javelin throw finals at the recently concluded World Athletics Championships in Budapest. What made India a leading contender?

I am just reiterating what other athletes have said, that the mental barrier that we had went away after my victory in Tokyo 2020. Back then, I felt that we can now compete with the best and win. Everyone works hard, but being mentally tough is also important.... With international exposure, we have seen how training is done abroad and are implementing the same plan.

Q. There's a healthy rivalry between you and Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem, which will carry forward to the Asian Games. How do you keep the India vs Pak noise aside?

You compete together and, of course, you push to take your country to the top. But after that, you should appreciate each other. Arshad congratulated me after my victory and it's my responsibility to do the same. We should respect all athletes irrespective of the country.

Q. Can we have multiple medallists in javelin at the Asian Games?

There will be two athletes at the Asian Games, so one can hope for it. I was the happiest that three Indians were in the top six at the World Athletics Championships finals. Everyone noticed how javelin in India is booming. As we become a powerhouse, one can hope for more podium finishes.

with Suhani Singh

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